

# Fate's Edge

## Essential Starting Guide

---

### GM & Player Reference — One Region, One Road

*“The road is a ledger. Every broken wheel is a debt, every lit lamp a witness. The only question is: what are you willing to owe?”*  
— *Dusana of the Raven Road*

**Welcome to Fate's Edge.** This guide contains everything you need to start playing—core rules, character creation, one region (Acasia), GM procedures, and a starter adventure hook. No other books required.

## 1 The Philosophy of Consequence

### 1.1 Narrative First

**Every roll tells a story.** In Fate's Edge, mechanics serve the story, not the other way around. When you roll dice, you are not asking “did I succeed?”—you are asking “what happens next?”

**The Golden Rule:** When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story. Set DV=3, Position=Controlled, and let the dice fall.

### 1.2 Safety at the Table

Fate's Edge explores mature themes. Use these tools to keep play safe:

- **X-Card:** Any player may say “X” to stop a scene. No questions asked.
- **Lines:** Content that will not appear (e.g., “no harm to children”).
- **Veils:** Content that fades to black (e.g., “romance is implied, not described”).

Establish these in Session Zero.

## 2 The Core Resolution

### 2.1 The 90-Second Loop

Every meaningful action follows this cycle:

1. **Declare** your intent and approach (Attribute + Skill).
2. **GM sets DV** (2–5+) and **Position** (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate).
3. **Roll** dice pool (Attribute + Skill d10s).
4. **Count successes** (6–10 = 1 success). Each 1 = Story Beat (SB) for GM.
5. **Apply outcome** using the Outcome Matrix.
6. **GM spends SB** to introduce complications.

### 2.2 Difficulty Value (DV)

| Difficulty Values |                                       |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------|
| DV                | When to Use                           |
| 2                 | Routine – clear path, no pressure     |
| 3                 | Pressured – mild opposition (default) |
| 4                 | Hard – serious resistance             |
| 5+                | Extreme – dramatic gamble             |

**Default DV is 3.** Do not inflate DVs to “challenge” players—use Position instead.

### 2.3 Position

Position tells you how risky the action is and changes how dice behave:

| Position Effects |                   |                     |
|------------------|-------------------|---------------------|
| Position         | Frame             | Mechanical Effect   |
| Dominant         | You press advance | Re-roll one failure |
| Controlled       | Balanced norm     | No re-rolls         |
| Desperate        | Act under duress  | Re-roll one success |

**Pro tip:** Spend 1 Boon to improve Position by one step before rolling.

### 2.4 The Outcome Matrix

| Outcome Matrix              |                                                          |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Roll Result                 | What Happens                                             |
| Successes $\geq$ DV, SB = 0 | <b>Clean Success</b> – Intent achieved, no complication. |
| Successes $\geq$ DV, SB > 0 | <b>Success with SB</b> – Intent achieved; GM spends SB.  |
| 0 < Successes < DV          | <b>Partial</b> – Progress; gain 1 Boon.                  |
| Successes = 0               | <b>Miss</b> – No progress; gain 2 Boons; GM spends SB.   |

**A Partial is not failure.** It moves the story forward: improve Position for next attempt, reduce DV, succeed at reduced scale, or reveal information.

**A Miss is never “nothing happens.”** The GM must introduce a complication.

### 2.5 Critical Success (10s)

A roll of 10 counts as **two successes**. If the overall roll succeeds:

- **1 ten:** Strong success—improve Position or gain minor advantage.
- **2 tens:** Exceptional—choose two benefits.
- **3+ tens:** Legendary—decisive victory; clear 1 segment from a relevant clock.

## 3 Resources: Boons & Story Beats

### 3.1 Boons—Player Currency

Boons represent luck, momentum, and narrative leverage. **Spend them freely.**

### Boons at a Glance

| Earning Boons      | Gain                       | Spending Boons                  |
|--------------------|----------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Partial success    | Gain 1                     | Re-roll a die (1 Boon)          |
| Miss               | Gain 2                     | Improve Position (1 Boon)       |
| Bond-driven action | Gain 1 (once/bond/session) | Activate Asset (1 Boon)         |
| GM award           | +1 (rare)                  | Convert 2 → 1 XP (once/session) |

**Holding cap:** 5 Boons. At end of scene, reduce to 2 (excess lost).

**The Math of Fun:** Hoarding Boons for XP conversion starves the table of drama. A re-rolled failure or an improved Position creates a memorable moment. Spend Boons!

## 3.2 Story Beats (SB)—GM Currency

Every time a player rolls a 1, the GM gains Story Beats. Spend SB to introduce complications:

### SB Spend Menu

| Cost  | Complication                                             |
|-------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 SB  | Minor – noise, distraction, tick a clock +1              |
| 2 SB  | Moderate – alarm raised, lose advantage, worsen Position |
| 3+ SB | Major – reinforcements, scene shifts, break an asset     |

**Be aggressive with SB.** Unused pressure is wasted momentum.

## 4 Injury & Exhaustion

### 4.1 Fatigue—The Weight of the World

Each point of Fatigue worsens your Position. If already Desperate, each Fatigue imposes –1 die instead.

#### Fatigue Progression

| Fatigue Level | Effect                                                   |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| 1             | Position worsens one step                                |
| 2             | If already Desperate, –1 die; otherwise Position worsens |
| 3             | –2 dice (if already Desperate from Fatigue)              |
| 4+            | Collapse, KO, incapacitated                              |

**Recovery:** Short rest removes 2 Fatigue; full night's rest removes all.

### 4.2 Harm—Serious Injury

#### Harm Levels

| Harm Level | Effect                    |
|------------|---------------------------|
| Harm 1     | –1 die on related actions |
| Harm 2     | –1 dice on most actions   |
| Harm 3     | Incapacitated or dying    |

### 4.3 The Roller-Coaster Effect

**Taking Harm clears Fatigue.** The shock of a wound resets your exhaustion. This creates dramatic swings—a character near collapse who takes a wound and finds a second wind.

### 4.4 Armor Conversion

When you take Harm, armor converts some to Fatigue:

#### Armor Conversion

| Armor  | Harm 1    | Harm 2              | Harm 3                |   |
|--------|-----------|---------------------|-----------------------|---|
| Light  | Fatigue 1 | Harm 1<br>Fatigue 1 | + Harm 2<br>Fatigue 1 | + |
| Medium | Fatigue 1 | Fatigue 1           | Harm 2<br>Fatigue 1   | + |
| Heavy  | Fatigue 1 | Fatigue 1           | Fatigue 2             |   |

## 5 Building Your Character

### 5.1 10-Minute Checklist

Start with **32 XP** (max 36 with Bonds/Complications).

- Concept:** One sentence (origin, profession, defining trait).
- Attributes (1–5):** Spend XP—primary to 3 (9 XP), secondaries to 2 (6 XP each).
- Skills (0–5):** Spend 8–12 XP on key skills.
- Talents:** 1–3 talents (2–6 XP each).
- Patron (optional):** Choose a Patron for magic.
- Assets/Followers (optional):** Minor Asset (4 XP) or follower (Cap<sup>2</sup> XP).
- Bonds & Complications:** Up to +4 XP total.

### 5.2 Attributes

| Attributes |                              |                              |
|------------|------------------------------|------------------------------|
| Attribute  | What It Does                 | Example Skills               |
| Body       | Strength, agility, endurance | Melee, Athletics, Stealth    |
| Wits       | Perception, quick thinking   | Insight, Lore, Investigation |
| Spirit     | Willpower, intuition         | Arcana, Resolve, Survival    |
| Presence   | Charisma, leadership         | Sway, Command, Deception     |

**Cost to raise:** New rating  $\times$  3 XP. Downtime = new rating in days.

### 5.3 Skills

**Cost to raise:** New level  $\times$  2 XP. Downtime = new level in days.

| Core Skills   |           |             |
|---------------|-----------|-------------|
| Combat        | Physical  | Social      |
| Melee         | Athletics | Sway        |
| Ranged        | Stealth   | Command     |
| Brawl         | Endurance | Deception   |
| Tactics       | Craft     | Performance |
|               | Survival  | Insight     |
| Knowledge     | Magic     |             |
| Lore          | Arcana    |             |
| Investigation | Ritual    |             |
| Medicine      |           |             |

### 5.4 Sample Starting Build—The Duelist (32 XP)

- **Attributes:** Body 3 (15 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP)
- **Skills:** Melee 2 (6 XP), Athletics 1 (2 XP)
- **Talent:** Keen Senses (2 XP)
- **Total:** 31 XP (bank 1)

## 6 The Known World: Acasia

*“The Broken Province”*

### 6.1 Genre & Mood

**Low fantasy / mercenary realism / border feud.** Acasia is a former province of the Utaran Empire that festers in the space between famine and ambition. Every hill wears a crown, every bridge demands a price, and every road curves back to the same cursed crossroads.

### 6.2 What You Notice First

The smell of mildew on old parchment and wet ash. The way every milestone has been recarved. The silence of a village that heard you coming and chose not to open its gates.

### 6.3 The One Rule That Kills Newcomers

**Never sign a contract on a bridge.** The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature.

### 6.4 Key Factions

| Acasia Factions       |                  |                                 |
|-----------------------|------------------|---------------------------------|
| Faction               | Leader           | Goal                            |
| Broken March          | Mar-gravine Mira | Keep province from fracturing   |
| Lame King's Claimants | Oren "Tin Crown" | Be recognised as true sovereign |
| Free Companies        | Various captains | Find permanent contracts        |
| Blackwood Matriarchs  | Hedge-witches    | Survive the Curse               |

### 6.5 The Curse of Acasia

The land remembers what we did—and what we failed to do. Every broken milestone is a forgotten promise. Every abandoned vineyard is a harvest we chose not to plant. **Mechanical effect:** When crossing a bridge or crossroads, roll Spirit + Resolve (DV 3). On a failure, the Curse stirs—gain 1 Fatigue or a minor complication (GM's choice).

### 6.6 Acasia Mini-Generator (d6)

1. A bridge toll has tripled overnight; the toll-keeper is a deserter from your old company.
2. A hedge-witch offers to break your blood-debt—for the memory of your first kill.
3. The Lame King travels with a mute jester who writes prophecies on fallen leaves.
4. Bandits stole a Blackwood Matriarch's curse-box. Recover it before it opens.

5. A free company captain wants to hire you—but their last three hires died of “accidents.”
6. The Margravine’s seal is missing. Whoever finds it can rewrite border law.

## 7 Running Fate’s Edge

### 7.1 The GM Mindset

You are not a referee or a narrator robot. You are a **co-creator of drama**. Your tools (SB, clocks) are not punishments—they are how you play the game. When you spend a Story Beat to tick a clock, you are making a move. Enjoy it.

### 7.2 Your Defaults

When in doubt:

- **DV: 3**
- **Position: Controlled**
- **Consequence:** Fatigue, time pressure, or exposure
- **Clocks:** One short clock tied to the scene

### 7.3 What You Are Doing

- Stating Position clearly and confidently
- Letting partials move the story forward
- Spending Story Beats to make failure interesting
- Allowing success to create new problems

### 7.4 The Three-Clock Guideline

Keep 1–3 active clocks per scene:

| Clock Sizes |                                  |
|-------------|----------------------------------|
| Segments    | When to Use                      |
| 4           | Short, straightforward challenge |
| 6           | Standard scene or tension        |
| 8           | Extended or complex problem      |
| 10          | Epic or campaign-long pressure   |

### 7.5 GM Survival Tips

#### 7.5.1 When Players Go Off the Rails

Do not panic. Ask: “*What is your goal?*” Name the simplest obstacle—then set Position and DV.

#### 7.5.2 When Players Hoard Boons

Remind them: “*Boons are not XP tokens—they are dramatic fuel.*” Introduce time pressure that forces spending.

#### 7.5.3 When a Scene Stalls

- Ask a leading question: “*What are you afraid of here?*”
- Tick a clock: “*While you argue, the fire spreads—Collapse [4] advances 1.*”
- Cut to another player.

#### 7.5.4 When You Don’t Know a Rule

Make a ruling that keeps the story moving. Default to DV 3, Controlled Position. Look it up later.

## 8 The Lantern at Dusk

*A Starter Adventure in Acasia*

### 8.1 Setup

The party is hired by **Elder Sarai** of the remote village of Duskwood. A terrible blight is spreading from the old barrow in the hills—the same barrow where a cursed lantern was buried centuries ago. The lantern must be brought to a stone circle in the valley to break the curse.

### 8.2 What the Party Knows

- The lantern is in the central chamber of the barrow.
- The barrow is guarded by restless spirits (the Duskwights).
- A rival treasure hunter, **Quick Lena**, has also entered the barrow.
- The curse will kill the village’s crops in three days.

### 8.3 Clocks

| Adventure Clocks     |                                                          |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Clock                | Effect                                                   |
| <b>Barrow</b>        | Col- Ticks on failure inside. At 6, entrance seals.      |
| <b>Lena’s Agenda</b> | Ticks each scene inside. At 4, Lena takes lantern first. |

## 8.4 Scenes

### 8.4.1 Scene 1—The Entry (DV 3, Controlled)

Obstacle: Cave-in blocks the way (Body + Athletics). **Partial:** Tick Barrow Collapse +1. **Miss:** Mark Harm 1, tick Collapse +1.

### 8.4.2 Scene 2—The Spirit Corridor (DV 3, Controlled)

Three Duskwrights demand an offering (a memory or a secret). Roll Presence + Sway. **Partial:** They also steal random equipment. **Miss:** They attack (Cap 2, Harm 1 each).

### 8.4.3 Scene 3—The Lantern Chamber

Quick Lena is trying to pry the lantern loose. Confront her: Presence + Sway (DV 3, Controlled). **Partial:** She agrees to split the reward but demands a favor later (start Debt Clock [4]). **Miss:** She triggers a trap—tick Collapse +2.

### 8.4.4 Scene 4—Escape (Skill Challenge)

The party needs **3 successes before 2 failures** to escape. Each PC describes their approach. DV 3, Position Desperate. Each failure ticks Collapse +1.

## 8.5 Resolution

Return the lantern to the stone circle. Break the curse with Spirit + Lore (DV 2). **Partial:** Curse lifts, but lantern attracts another danger soon. **Miss:** Curse pushed back one year; a dark spirit escapes.

## 8.6 Advancement

Each PC earns **6–10 XP** at the end.

## 9 Basic Magic

### 9.1 The Five Paths (Quick Reference)

#### Magic Paths

| Path        | Complexity | Cost            | Type | Best For                       |
|-------------|------------|-----------------|------|--------------------------------|
| Runkeeper   | Low        | Obligation      |      | First-timers, reliable casters |
| Cantor      | Medium     | Corruption      |      | Bards, risk-takers             |
| Invoker     | Medium     | Obligation time |      | + Ritual specialists           |
| Summoner    | High       | Leash Boons     |      | + Pet-class fans               |
| Free Caster | High       | Backlash        |      | Improv players                 |

For first magical characters, play a Runkeeper.

### 9.2 Runkeeper—The Reliable Path

**Requirements:** Familiar (Thiasos, 2 XP) + Codex (4 XP) + Patron.

**Invoking a Rite:** 1 action. Mark +1 Obligation. Effect works as written.

**Push It:** Once per scene, mark +1 Obligation to amplify (+1 die or +1 Effect).

**Obligation Capacity:** Spirit + Presence. Exceeding capacity: 1 Fatigue per segment.

### 9.3 Sample—The Traveler's Runkeeper

**Kestra, Traveler's Runkeeper** (36XP)

- Spirit 3 (9 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP)
- Lore 2 (6 XP), Insight 1 (2 XP), Sway 1 (2 XP)
- Talents: Familiar (2 XP), Codex (4 XP)
- Rites: Road-Sense (4 XP), Traveler's Boon (5 XP)
- Obligation Capacity: 4 (Spirit 3 + Presence 1)

### 9.4 Free Casting—The TAGS System

For improvisational magic, construct spells using TAGS:

$$DV = 1 + \text{number of TAGS}$$

Dangerous TAGS (Leap, Fold, Gate, Transform, Dominate) add +2 DV.

#### 9.4.1 Example Spells

- **Light [Illuminate]** – DV 2. Create small, sustained light.

- **HEAL [HEAL]** – DV 2. Remove 1 Fatigue from self or touched ally.
- **Shield of Air [WARD] [DEFEND]** – DV 3. Gain Position +1 on next defense.
- **Flame Cloak [BURNING] [AREA]** – DV 3. Enemies suffer –1 die to approach.

**Backlash:** On a Miss or when GM spends SB, magic backfires—Fatigue 1, Harm 1, or a thematic complication.

## 10 Advancement & XP

### 10.1 Earning XP (Per Session)

| XP Breakdown     |      |
|------------------|------|
| Achievement      | XP   |
| Attendance       | +2   |
| Major objectives | +2–4 |
| Discoveries      | +1–2 |
| Hard choices     | +1–2 |
| Story engagement | +1–3 |
| Personal goals   | +1–2 |

**Game pace options:** Gritty (4–6 XP/session), Standard (6–10), Epic (10–14).

### 10.2 Spending XP

| XP Costs           |                |                    |
|--------------------|----------------|--------------------|
| Improvement        | XP Cost        | Downtime           |
| Attribute increase | New rating × 3 | New rating in days |
| Skill increase     | New level × 2  | New level in days  |
| Minor Asset        | 4 XP           | 1 day              |
| Standard Asset     | 8 XP           | 1 week             |
| Major Asset        | 12 XP          | 1 month            |
| Minor Talent       | 2–4 XP         | 3–10 days          |
| Major Talent       | 5–8 XP         | 1–2 weeks          |

### 10.3 Tiers of Play

| Character Tiers |          |             |
|-----------------|----------|-------------|
| Tier            | XP Range | Reputation  |
| I: Novice       | 0–40     | Local       |
| II: Seasoned    | 41–90    | Regional    |
| III: Veteran    | 91–150   | National    |
| IV: Paragon     | 151–220  | Continental |
| V: Mythic       | 221+     | Legendary   |

## 11 Quick Reference Tables

### 11.1 Combat in Brief

- **Turn:** 1 Action + 1 Move
- **Move:** Shift one range band (Close ↔ Near ↔ Far)
- **Opportunity Attack:** Leaving Close range without Disengage provokes one free melee attack.
- **Sidestep Strike:** Move one band as part of melee attack; worsen Position by one step.

### 11.2 Weapon Modifiers

| Melee Weapons                      |       |      |
|------------------------------------|-------|------|
| Weight Notes                       | Close | Near |
| Light                              | +2d   | +1d  |
| Quick in tight quarters            |       |      |
| Medium                             | +1d   | +2d  |
| Set once/scene or –1d first attack |       |      |
| Heavy                              | –1d   | +3d  |
| Set once/scene or –2d first attack |       |      |

### 11.3 Range Bands

- **Close:** Touching distance—grapples, knife-work
- **Near:** Same room/area—a rush away
- **Far:** Same site but distant—requires route or time
- **Absent:** Off-screen—requires scene change

### 11.4 Skill Synergies—Creative Pairs

### Alternative Skill Pairs

| Action        | Standard Pair        | Alternative Pair                        |
|---------------|----------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Climbing      | Body + Athletics     | Wits + Athletics (clever route)         |
| Persuading    | Presence + Sway      | Wits + Sway (logical argument)          |
| Investigating | Wits + Investigation | Spirit + Investigation (intuitive leap) |
| Feinting      | Wits + Melee         | Presence + Melee (intimidation)         |

*“The coin that never spends is the one you don’t remember taking.”*

— Serafine of the Velvet Touch

Fate’s Edge Essential Guide — CC BY 4.0 — Nicholas A. Gasper

*Set down in Castra Ferrum, Year of the Iron Harvest*

## 11.5 Final GM Mantra

Set the DV low. Make the world react honestly. Let the pressure do the work. And remember—you are playing the game too.

## 12 Session Zero Checklist

Use this checklist to start your campaign.

1. **Lines & Veils** – What content is off-limits or only implied?
2. **Tone** – Cinematic action? Grim survival? Political intrigue? Dark horror?
3. **Campaign length** – One-shot, short arc (3-6 sessions), or long campaign (12+)?
4. **Character hooks** – Each player shares one goal and one fear.
5. **Patron interest** – Which Patrons (if any) are already watching the party?
6. **Starting situation** – Where does the story begin?
7. **House rules** – Any optional subsystems you plan to use?
8. **Scheduling & attendance** – How often do you meet? What if a player misses?
9. **Player-GM contract** – “We are co-creators, not adversaries.”
10. **Resource mindset** – “Boons are not XP tokens. Spend them. Embrace failure.”

*“Now close the book—or keep reading. The road is waiting.”*